



PORTO PORTUGAL

Bacalhau in the Port Capital

In Portugal's second city, Porto – famous for its port-wine lodges – the revitalized riverside Ribeira district is now a UNESCO World Heritage site and provides a magnificent backdrop for sampling that most Portuguese of foodstuffs: *bacalhau*, or dried, salted codfish. In skilled hands, this defies its unpromising beginnings to become no less than the country's national dish.



Arriving in Porto by rail or road, there's a first, dramatic view of the broad Douro River, which – more than any monument or museum, more than its stunning Baroque architecture – gives the downtown its distinct character. From the elevated medieval cathedral, an intricate jumble of stepped alleys tumbles down to the river's north bank and to the sparkling waterfront known as the Ribeira. Fish restaurants line the arcaded quayside, some tucked into former warehouses, while above looms the iconic Ponte Dom Luís I, the 19th-century double-decker bridge whose graceful profile frames both river and city. A meal here on the quayside, looking across the river to the port-wine lodges with their names emblazoned across their roofs, is an absolute must on a trip to Porto.

For all the Ribeira's alfresco restaurants and riverside promenades, Porto remains at heart a straightforward working city, something that is reflected in its down-to-earth cuisine. The locals, for example, are known as *tripeiros* – tripe-eaters – due to their penchant for tripe dishes, but there's another classic dish on the menu in every Porto establishment that's more palatable to most visitors.

In the 15th and early 16th centuries, the Portuguese were the world's greatest maritime explorers, opening up trading routes to Africa and India. Long sea journeys were made possible in part by the preservation of food, notably dried, salted codfish (*bacalhau*), which became one of the first truly global dishes – eaten from Portugal to Scandinavia, and in far-flung Portuguese colonies from Brazil to Macau.

After centuries of experimentation, the number of Portuguese *bacalhau* recipes is famously large – some say 365, one for every day of the year, others say a thousand. Every region has its own specialty, and so does every chef. In Porto, the favored preparation is named after the 19th-century cod merchant who invented it, *bacalhau à Gomes de Sá* – baked with potato and onion, and garnished with olives and hard-boiled eggs – but it also comes boiled, roasted, or fried, poached in olive oil, and cooked with everything from cream to chili peppers. It's a popular festive meal, with Portuguese families sitting down on Christmas Eve to *bacalhau com todos* (“with everything”), served with boiled potatoes, chickpeas, cabbage, and carrots. It may seem strange to anyone brought up on the idea of a Christmas turkey or ham, but the *bacalhau*-loving Portuguese wouldn't have it any other way.

A Day in Porto

Porto regards itself as the capital of northern Portugal, and it's a vibrant, cultural university city with a strong Baroque heritage and a fascinating riverside district.

MORNING Start with coffee and fresh bread in the **Mercado do Bolhão** market, then walk to the **Torre dos Clérigos** (Clérigos Tower) for an eagle-eye city view. Visit the medieval **Sé** (cathedral), after which you can descend the stepped alleys to the **Ribeira district**, where former merchant wealth is evident in buildings like the stunning Baroque **São Francisco church** and the **Palácio da Bolsa** (Stock Exchange).

AFTERNOON The Douro River has been at the heart of Porto's life and trade for centuries, and taking a **river cruise** under the city's famous bridges brings much of the history to life. Afterward, take the bus out to the **Fundação Serralves**, Porto's stunning contemporary art museum and sculpture park.

EVENING Drink an apéritif in the **Solar do Vinho do Porto**, the bar of the Port Wine Institute, before returning to the quayside restaurants of the **Ribeira**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Porto Airport is the main airport for northern Portugal. Fast, reliable **intercity trains** connect Porto and Lisbon (around three hours).

WHERE TO STAY

Grande Hotel de Paris (inexpensive) is a charming downtown mansion. www.ghparis.pt
Guest House Douro (moderate) has stylish B&B riverside rooms. www.guesthousedouro.com
Pestana Porto (expensive) is a classy boutique hotel on the quayside. www.pestana.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Posto de Turismo Centro, Rua Clube dos Fenianos 25; www.portoturismo.pt

